

BACKGROUND UNEP

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Introduction

"The World's Hidden Criminal Network: The Illegal Trade in Exotic Animals"

Greetings, delegates, welcome to the 16th edition of the Model of the United Nations Instituto Oriente MUNIO. The United Nations Environment Programme, on behalf of the Instituto Oriente, are grateful to the delegates for being part of this debate and for their initiative in seeking viable solutions to this topic. We, as a Chair, are willing to guide you on this model and hope that each one of you will fully apply your skills to make an outstanding contribution throughout the entire model.



In order to understand the consequences, causes, and prevention of the illegal trade of live exotic animals, it is important to take into account the affected areas of this problem. The illegal trade in exotic animals is the conservation crisis of current times. This is severely threatening wildlife species all over the world, as traffickers and organized criminal networks are constantly seeking profit, regardless of the consequences, to satisfy customer demand. Unfortunately, online platforms are now the most used sources for the trafficking of wildlife for exotic species.

According to the Wildlife Conservation Society, illicit wildlife trafficking is estimated to be between $7.8 billion and $10 billion per year. These numbers show that illicit wildlife trafficking is the fourth largest global illegal trade after narcotic substances, human trafficking, and counterfeit products.

This topic puts the local ecosystems and all the species under pressure when they are facing threats such as over-fishing, pollution, dredging, deforestation and other forms of habitat destruction; it also involves a significant imbalance in local economies, impacting the local communities.

People in rural areas across the tropical forest and other ecosystems are closely bound to the hunting of wildlife for food or personal benefits. In many transitioning countries, they depend on hunting as a fallback in times of hardship when it comes to the market economy.

Deeply concerned for the species, this committee knows the importance of this topic in the world and how it is affecting both ecosystems and developing countries. Since this problem has been intensified in recent years, it has evolved into an important and urgent topic to take care of. The delegates will have to search for the most viable solutions to protect these species, their well-being, security, and the assurance of their preservation.

This document contains key information about the topic that will help you to carry out this model in the best way possible.

History of the Committee

It all started with the 1972 Stockholm Conference, also known as the United Nations Conference on the Human Environment, which was the first world conference, organized by the United Nations, about global environmental issues, stating 26 principles aimed at guiding nations in preserving and addressing the human environment, recognizing that a healthy environment is a human right. This was a crucial event in recognizing the importance of environmental issues on a global scale. This conference gave rise to the creation of the United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) to deal with environmental concerns and raise awareness about sustainable development.

The United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) serves as the leading environmental authority within the UN system. It plays a fundamental role in promoting transformative action to address the three most interconnected planetary crises: climate change, biodiversity and ecosystem degradation, and the growing impact of pollution and waste.

This year's topics in debate

- Air Quality
- Biosafety
- Digital transformations
- Fresh water
- Green economy
- Resource Efficiency
- Protection, conservation, restoration, and sustainable management of the world's marine and coastal areas.
- Sustainable Development Goals
- Protection, restoration, and sustainable management of forests.

Its importance throughout the years

Through scientific studies, policy support, intergovernmental coordination, and public advocacy, the United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) helps humanity to foster climate stability, live in harmony with nature, and forge a pollution-free future, in line with the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

The United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) has served as a neutral convener of Member States, civil society, the private sector, and UN agencies to address the most critical environmental challenges. From protecting species to

restoring the ozone layer, the United Nations Environment Programme has facilitated international agreements that have made global environmental action possible throughout the years. Today, the United Nations Environment Programme hosts the United Nations Environment Assembly, the world's highest-level decision-making body on the environment.

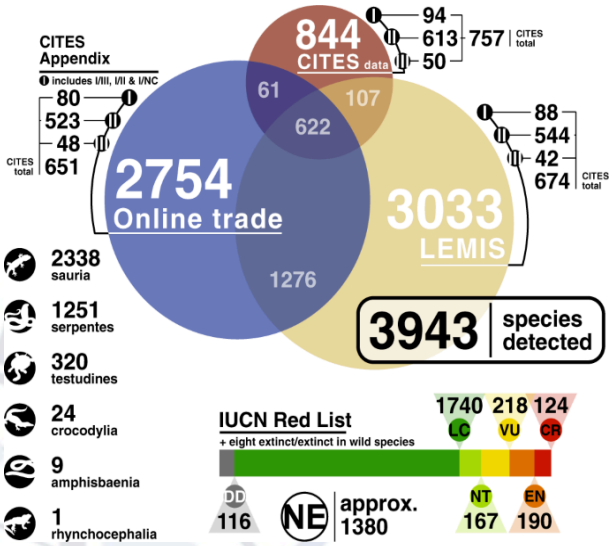


In the five decades since its founding, UNEP's convening capacity, rigorous scientific research, and public advocacy have helped to boldly advance the global environmental agenda. In particular, UNEP has led efforts to counter climate change, protect endangered species, end deforestation, repair the hole in the ozone layer, and phase out toxic leaded fuels.

One of the key environmental topics UNEP is actively addressing this year is the Nature-Climate-Water Nexus & Private Sector Action, followed by the Global Plastics Treaty, Plastic Pollution & the Global Plastics Hub. All of these topics are currently being debated, and the United Nations is already taking significant action, including on the illegal wildlife trade.

Long Term

Between November 2004 and January 2005, the International Fund for Animal Welfare found thousands of endangered animals and animal products available for purchase over the internet, causing the reinforcement of the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora (CITES) rules and has prohibit the trade of different species of animals.



Statistics show how the use of the media has become an essential tool for the illegal trade in exotic animals.

Political impact

CITES, an international agreement signed by 183 governments, has voted to ban or limit trade in many animal species sought after as pets. Many countries also prohibit domestic sales or possession of certain animals (Hall, 2021). In addition, nonprofits all around the world have been trying to shut down the exotic pet trade by educating people about the harms of owning these animals. Research conducted by the World Animal Protection found that the best way to discourage people from owning an exotic animal is to emphasize the risks they pose to humans, not the animals themselves. A significant number of the affected areas are home to endangered mountain gorillas that are displaced, lose their food supply, or are poached for use as bushmeat that is then sold to miners and armed groups (South & Brisman, 2013; Nelleman et al, 2010).

Economic impact

Many countries rely on wildlife-related activities, such as ecotourism, for economic revenue and employment. The depletion of charismatic species due to poaching can diminish the appeal of natural habitats for tourists, leading to economic losses for local communities and governments. Furthermore, the illicit trade in wildlife products is often linked to other forms of organized crime; this can disrupt the economy of the countries and lead to social instability in affected regions. (*An*



Introduction To Illegal Wildlife Trade And Its Effects On Biodiversity And Society, 2023)

Furthermore, many countries do not prioritize the illegal wildlife trade adequately, and therefore, not enough resources are allocated. The loss of resources due to illegal wildlife trade was estimated to be 48–153 billion United States dollars annually, about 10 years ago. This considerably exceeds the funds annually spent on restoration and conservation. (*An Introduction To Illegal Wildlife Trade And Its Effects On Biodiversity And Society*, 2023)

Social impact

While some studies state that many people with a lack of economic resources rely on poaching and other illegal activities for their income. Local communities have ancestral rights to hunt for subsistence in their regions.
And the connection of organised crime threatens local communities' livelihood and exposes them to associated crimes such as violence, forced labour, or even loss of life. On the other hand, some local communities have started to protect their wildlife from poaching or trade. (Brink, 2024), (*An Introduction To Illegal Wildlife Trade And Its Effects On Biodiversity And Society*, 2023).

Short Term

Since 2020, the illicit trade of wildlife and their parts has threatened millions of animals' survival worldwide, accelerated the biodiversity crisis, and endangered the planet. But it is not just animals that suffer. Wildlife trafficking causes devastating impacts on ecosystems, human health, and the global economy. The illegal trafficking of exotic animals has become the fourth-largest illicit market worldwide. This trade directly impacts biodiversity, which contributes to the spread of multiple diseases and fuels organized crime networks to continue operating internationally, as said previously. (*Wildlife Trafficking: Why battling this illicit trade is crucial | ICE*, 2025)

Political Impact

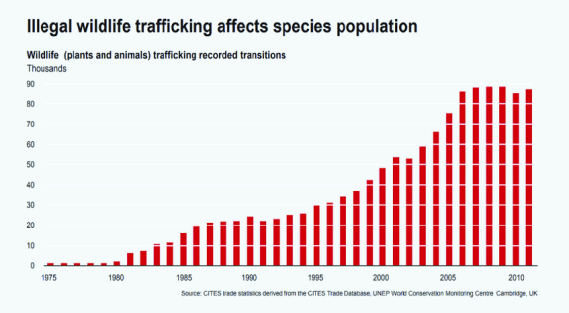
Wildlife trafficking can undermine good governance and the rule of law and, in some cases, threaten national stability. Several reports also document the impact of land clearance for mining operations and infrastructure projects on local animal species and humans in the Democratic Republic of Congo. (United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, 2019)

Despite international attention, the legal framework in many countries remains weak. In 2021 and 2022, Operation Thunder, coordinated by the International Criminal Police Organization (INTERPOL) and the World Customs Organization, seized thousands of illegally traded specimens, yet most of the offenders faced only minor penalties or none at all. (United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, 2019)

Corruption remains a serious barrier to enforcement, particularly in transit countries. In 2023, a leaked investigation in West Africa exposed customs officers who had been paid to allow shipments of endangered reptiles and birds into Europe and the Middle East. (United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, 2019)

Social Impact

Not only is wildlife trafficking a grave concern for biodiversity, but it also hurts local economies and overall human health. Many local communities worldwide rely on wildlife tourism as a primary source of income. The loss of wildlife directly decreases tourism, causing a ripple effect that impacts restaurants, hotels, and other sources of livelihood for local community members. (Financial Crime Academy, 2025)

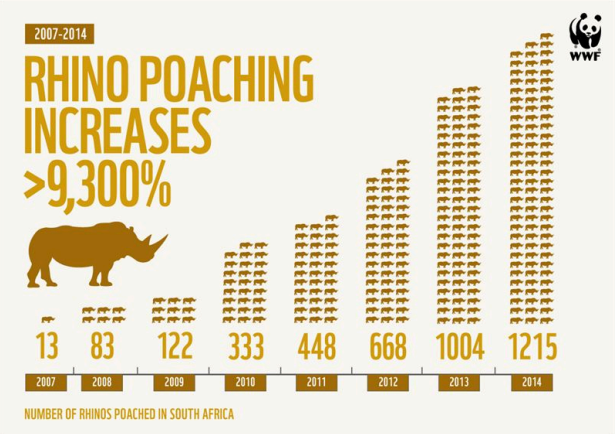


International wildlife trade directly leads to increased zoonotic pandemics and infectious diseases. Wet markets (live animal markets where wildlife is sold in urban settings) are breeding grounds for zoonotic diseases, like the one that likely caused the COVID-19 outbreak. Consuming infected bushmeat can also transmit diseases to humans. Stopping wildlife trafficking and trade is necessary to prevent the next global pandemic. (Rare, 2024)

Economic Impact

Wildlife trafficking undermines and threatens the ability and efforts of States to manage their natural resources. It can result in severe economic losses, which particularly affect developing countries that rely on revenue generated by legal trade. (United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, 2019)

Wildlife, forest, and fisheries crime can threaten rural livelihoods where people's subsistence and income rely on wildlife, including those based on ecotourism. According to the Wildlife Conservation Society, unreported and unregulated fisheries trade alone are estimated to be between $4.2 billion and $9.5 billion per year. Illicit wildlife trafficking is estimated to be between $7.8 billion and $10 billion per year, and illegal timber trade is estimated to be as much as $7 billion per year. (*Wildlife Trafficking: Why battling this illicit trade is crucial | ICE*, 2025)



Topic and the United Nations

UN's vision of the issue



While the United Nations has historically focused on broader conservation and environmental protection, in recent decades it has increasingly acknowledged wildlife trafficking as a transnational crime that fuels corruption and the capacity of serious threat to global biodiversity, environmental sustainability, and public health. This undermines the rule of law and endangers both human and animal life; for those reasons, the United Nations strongly opposes the illegal trade in exotic animals and advocates for global cooperation to end this issue through different strategies with different focuses.

Declarations and resolutions

Through key declarations such as the United Nations General Assembly Resolution of 30 July 2015, which expresses concern that illicit trafficking in protected species of wild fauna and flora is, in some cases, an increasingly sophisticated form of transnational organized crime. This activity poses a threat to health, safety, security, good governance, and the sustainable development of States, while the resolution also calls for firm and strengthened national measures, and an enhanced regional and global response.

It tackles both supply and demand by strengthening legislation necessary for the prevention, investigation, and prosecution of offences, treating certain wildlife offences as serious crimes, providing them to be treated as predicate offences, supporting the exchange of evidence between States, and taking steps to prohibit, prevent, and counter corruption.

European decision-makers, African delegations, and Non-Governmental Organizations met in the European Parliament on 27 June 2023 to discuss how to best combat wildlife trafficking, which is crucial to halting biodiversity loss.

The event had a strong focus on the United States Action Plan Against Wildlife Trafficking. Several topics were discussed, including the need to prevent wildlife trafficking and address its root causes, the existing policy frameworks and

regulations, the key role of local communities, as well as the importance of global partnerships.

Ms. Tebatso Baleseng, Deputy Head of Mission, Embassy of Botswana to the European Union, referred to the counter-poaching operations in place set out in the national anti-poaching strategy. She added that inter-agency committees meet weekly to share intelligence to plan and implement law enforcement operations.

The sustainable use of wildlife was cited in several efforts. Nature-based tourism in wildlife was highlighted as being important to support conservation and to finance anti-poaching operations.

Programmes

UNEP is working with other United Nations agencies and secretariats such as CITES to suppress illegal sale and trafficking in wildlife both domestically and internationally. It works to improve the validation of national legislation and helps countries partner up to address transboundary issues of trafficked products at ports of entry and exit. Globally, corruption is a serious problem that delays combating the illegal wildlife trade. This is why UNEP provides support through training of judges, law enforcement, and customs officials on combating wildlife crime and developing the rule of law.



A campaign called " Wild for Life" is a campaign that aims to mobilize public support and knowledge of the topic in order to end the illegal trade in endangered species, such as exotic animals. It uses storytelling and participatory innovation to connect with local communities and promote sustainable practices.

UNEP also raises the public's awareness and understanding of the social, economic, and environmental impacts of the illegal trade using famous influencers, which can reach one billion people through their social channels. In this way, it aims to strengthen international efforts to develop and demand reduction for illegally-sourced wildlife products.

Controversy Points

Why is it a controversial topic?

Throughout decades and recent years, illegal wildlife trafficking has been a topic of concern and debate. The seriousness of the topic is often overlooked. This has led not only to the deterioration of several ecosystems, but also to their existence, both local and global. The retrogress of the problem is due to the fact that the demand for larger and more glamorous specimens means that hunters and collectors often aim for the fittest individuals from the breeding population, with serious consequences for future generations.



Illegal or unsustainable wildlife trade (IUWT) affects numerous species, ecosystems, and human communities. IUWT can cause direct and indirect harm to targeted or non-targeted species, the loss of ecosystem services, and act as a conduit for potentially invasive species, while being a pathway for zoonotic diseases, and disrupting local and global economies. It is a lucrative illicit activity, whose estimates range from 7 to 23 billion USD per year, excluding logging and fisheries.

Tackling IUWT and mitigating its impacts requires a complex, multi-disciplinary strategy at global, national, and local levels that can address a wide range of challenges. Laws may be insufficient, out of data, ignore relevant science, or be inadequately enforced; furthermore, 'legally harvested' does not necessarily mean 'sustainably produced' or 'sustainably managed'.

Since IUWT is a complex, dynamic, and inter-jurisdictional problem, finding integrated solutions requires a multidisciplinary approach involving several actors, the use of the most recent advances in science, and recognition of different viewpoints. Given the inherent global scope of the challenge, it will take time, economic resources, and commitment for any integrated approach to be developed and implemented.

What positions are there on the topic?

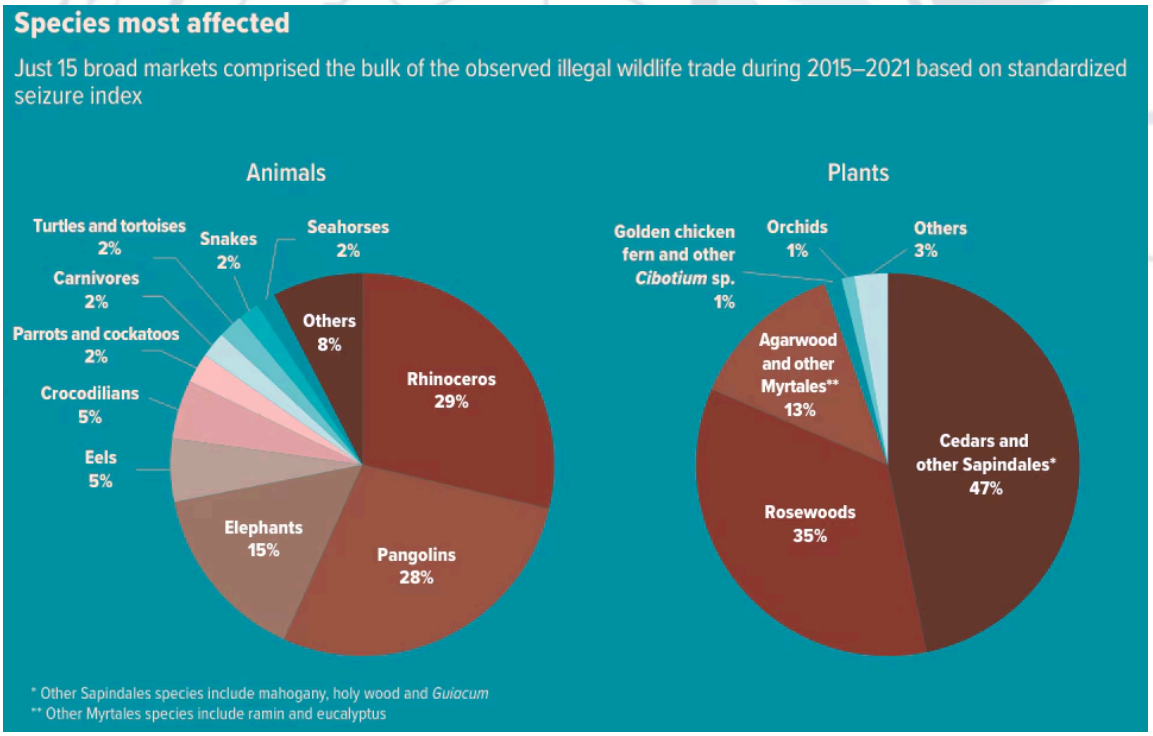
In the context of illegal trafficking of exotic animals, four main positions can be identified.

- Against trafficking: This position argues that illegal trafficking of exotic animals is unethical, cruel, and environmentally destructive. It calls for strict international regulation, enforcement and punishment to eliminate traffic completely.

- In favor of regulation and control: In which it is accepted that trafficking exists and is considered a risk to global health and social justice, recognizing the risk of zoonotic diseases and the increase in corruption.

- Ambivalent: This position acknowledges the economic benefits and environmental harms of the illegal trade. It does not clearly support or oppose it, but considers that banning it completely is not viable.

- In favor: This viewpoint defends the prevalence of animal trafficking in regions where it is seen as a cultural or economic necessity. It argues that for some communities, this activity is a traditional way of life.



Objectives

Representing the United Nations Environment Program, this Chair aims to raise awareness about the illegal trade in exotic animals and how this topic affects numerous aspects, such as ecosystem degradation, among others, and to acknowledge the repercussions of alterations on the ecological balance.

In this section of the document, the delegates will be able to find essential points that may help to reach viable and sustainable solutions to solve the different aspects regarding the topic, also taking into consideration everything that has been stated so far.

With the importance of the topic being cleared, this Chair appeals to the delegates to take into account some aspects encouraged by the United Nations Environment Program:

- Raising awareness and educating people about the causes and effects.
- Supporting eco-friendly alternatives for the high demand of products made with the species.
- Legal reinforcement and international cooperation, collaborating with different organizations.
- Keeping and restoring the ecosystem along with the habitat of the animals.
- Detecting criminal networks and trafficking across borders.
- Improve the quality without affecting future generations.

We, as a Chair, have the objective that during and after the debate, our delegates come up with effective solutions for the issue. Although it is a topic that is not talked about enough, that does not diminish its importance, and, on the contrary, the aim is to encourage our delegates to work together and find the best solutions for this topic. This Chair intends to help the delegates to be able to explore their potential and find doable solutions for ending the suffering and the dangers that the illegal trade in exotic animals means. Additionally, we, as a Chair, would like to thank the High Command for their guidance throughout this preparation process and for considering us for this edition of MUNIO.



Conclusion

Currently, the illegal trade in exotic animals represents a danger to animals themselves and to humans. The topic is often known but not always understood as a serious issue in the world.

This criminal network creates health problems for animals and humans, endangers fauna and flora, magnifies the economic problems in different countries and communities, and causes political hassle; therefore, the illegal trade in exotic animals needs to be addressed.

Today, it is necessary to take action. The problem is already showing worrying statistics. If society waits longer to do something, it will already be too late; the imbalance of the wildlife industry is increasing every day, and traditions are being broken down as a consequence of this criminal network.

We, as a Chair, believe that, as mentioned before, this is an issue that is not discussed enough and consequently, must be debated to raise awareness about the seriousness of the issue and, at the same time, enter upon viable and sustainable solutions to put an end to this problem, and thus, give these species in question a dignified life in their respective ecosystems.

We, the members of this Chair, are fully dedicated to this committee. This committee holds a very special place in our hearts. We have invested our time, love, and energy into this document, and we are ready to bring out the best in ourselves and our delegates. May this be a space where our delegates can debate and express themselves with confidence so that they can all learn and grow together as a united committee.

Thank you, delegates, for choosing this committee and showing interest in the topic; this Chair is thankful for the trust given. We, as a Chair, expect you to give out your best, believe in yourselves, and be dedicated and full of passion. Enjoy every moment of this edition, and remember that the president, secretary, and moderator are always available.

"Every individual matters. Every individual has a role to play. Every individual makes a difference."
-Jane Goodall

Countries

Argentine Republic

In Argentina, more than 100 bird species, 20 reptiles, and 15 mammal species are known to be affected by trafficking. Of these, 20 are listed as threatened species, nationally and internationally.
Mammals were mostly involved in poaching events for their meat and fur, for which individuals were murdered. On the other hand, birds were mainly live-captured to be sold as pets.

Federative Republic of Brazil

Brazil contains 60% of the Amazon biome and holds over 13% of the world's biodiversity. However, many species—including turtles, fish, jaguars, birds, and primates—are illegally trafficked for domestic and international trade. Between 2012 and 2019, the most frequently seized items in the Amazon region included river turtles, ornamental fish, fish for consumption, and wild meat.

Kingdom of Thailand

Thailand is one of the major transit hubs for illegal wildlife trade in Southeast Asia. Between 2017 and 2019, over 4,500 kg of pangolin scales—representing approximately 12,500 individuals—were seized in the country. WEFCOM (Western Forest Complex), a world natural heritage site, is home to key wildlife species such as tigers, gaurs, bantengs, sambar deer, muntjacs, and serows.

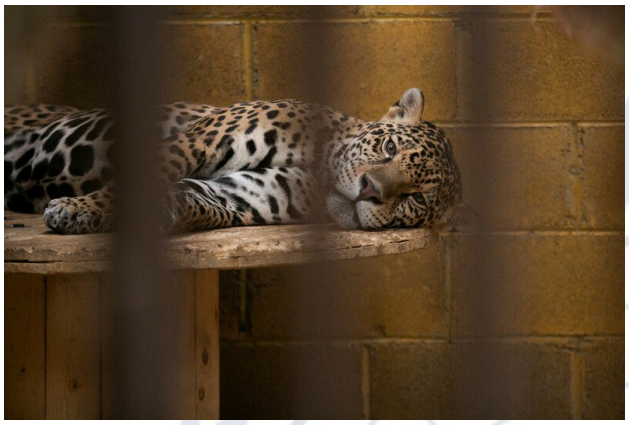


People's Republic of China

Traditional Chinese medicine, valued at an estimated $60 billion annually, is a key driver of the illegal wildlife trade. In 2017, it accounted for over 40% of China's pharmaceutical market, with demand increasing by 5–15% annually. Backed by

the government, Chinese companies are expanding production internationally, placing greater pressure on endangered species such as the saiga, tiger, and rhino.

United Mexican States



Mexico's ongoing social and security issues have diminished public interest in environmental crimes, including wildlife trafficking, compared to crimes considered to have "high social impact." As a result, environmental crimes are not given a proper place on government agendas, even though wildlife trafficking often occurs in conjunction with other crimes. Environmental crimes in the state of Tamaulipas have not been studied in depth despite it being located between the Sierra Madre Oriental and the Gulf of Mexico coast, making it the state in northern Mexico with the greatest biodiversity.

List of Countries:

Countries in G5:

1. French Republic
2. People's Republic of China
3. Russian Federation
4. United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland
5. United States of America

Members of the Organization:

6. Federal Republic of Somalia
7. Hellenic Republic
8. Islamic Republic of Pakistan
9. Kingdom of Denmark
10. Republic of Panama

Countries invited to the debate and listening countries:

11. Argentine Republic
12. Democratic Republic of the Congo
13. Federation of Malaysia
14. Federal Republic of Nigeria
15. Federal Republic of Somalia
16. Federative Republic of Brazil
17. Gabonese Republic
18. Kingdom of Cambodia
19. Kingdom of Thailand
20. Lebanese Republic
21. Lao People's Democratic Republic
22. Republic of Cameroon
23. Republic of Colombia
24. Republic of Ecuador
25. Republic of India
26. Republic of Indonesia
27. Republic of Peru
28. Republic of South Africa
29. Socialist Republic of Vietnam
30. United Mexican States

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"Those who believe in the world are the ones meant to change it."

President: Valeria Cid Meléndez
Moderator: Ana Camila Bautista Medellín
Secretary: Paulina Solano Rangel

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